Attack Timing

Active attacks occur for a variety of reasons, sometimes they are planned and other times not. Here, we show the timing of active attacks from 2000 to 2025, a critical element for premeditated attacks with the goal of maximizing casualties. As the plots demonstrate, some dimensions of time are more informative than others.

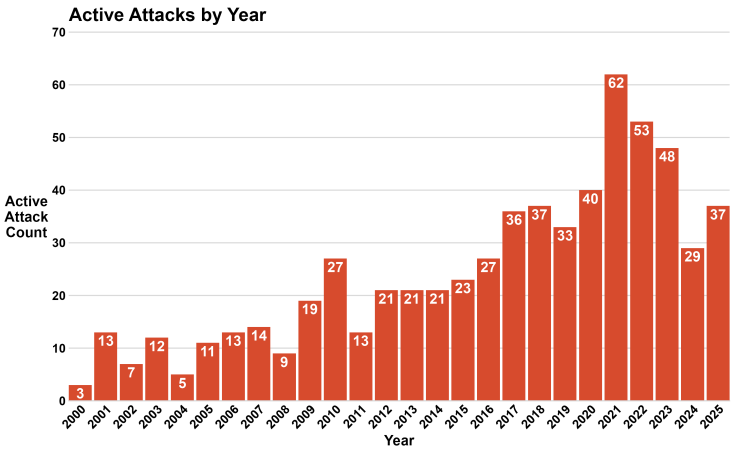
By Year

There appears to be more events in the last five years (mean = 45) than the first five years (mean = 8) or second five years (mean = 16); however, this may be an artifact of media coverage. Attacks that occurred during the first part of this data collection period likely did not get the national coverage that they do now. Furthermore, technology and search engines have improved dramatically over the 26 years of this data collection period.

By Month

In contrast to the obvious upward trend in attacks across years, there appear to be only a modest trend related to months of the year. Active Attacks tend to peak during the

By Year | By Month | By Day of the Week | By Hour of the Day



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warmer months of the year (e.g., April through August account for 47.8% of attacks), though this trend is not a strong one. The relationship with temperature is similar to trends observed for certain types of violent crime (e.g., aggravated assault, homicide) that also tend to peak during the warmest parts of the year.

By Day of the Week
Active attacks share no observable association with day of the week. This can be seen by the flat distribution of attacks across the week. So while there may be trends by year and month, attacks appear to be nearly equally likely on any given day of the week.

By Hour of the Day
Active attacks tend to cluster around midday. While attacks that begin at midday exactly are relatively infrequent (only 3.9% of attacks), the majority of attacks occur immediately before midday (8-11am hours account for 25.4% of attacks) or after midday (1-4pm hours account for 24.6% of attacks).